

“...[CAESAR] DREAMED THAT HE WAS FLYING ABOVE THE CLOUDS, AND NOW THAT HE WAS CLASPING THE HAND OF JUPITER.”

Suetonius, recounting Julius Caesar's dream the night before his murder in the Senate House in 44 BCE; from *Lives of the Caesars*



prevented the arrival of reinforcements, causing him to retreat, but he returned the next year with five legions (around 30,000 men). The Britons did not resist at first, but later, led by **Cassivelaunus**, chief of the Catuvellauni, they vigorously opposed the Romans all the way to the Thames River. When Cassivelaunus's stronghold at Wheathampstead fell, he sued for peace, and Caesar returned to Rome with hostages and the promise of tribute.

At the end of 54 BCE, shortly after Caesar's second expedition to Britain, another **revolt** in Gaul, this time led by the **Senones**, wiped out much of the Roman force there. After putting down the revolt, Caesar's attentions were diverted to Rome, where **political violence** had resulted in the murder of his former ally Clodius, and where Pompey had been elected sole consul in 52 BCE, rupturing the Triumvirate. Emboldened by the turmoil in Rome, the **Carnutes** revolted in Gaul. They were joined by the Averni, led by **Vercingetorix**, who won several skirmishes against Labienus. Vercingetorix also defeated Caesar himself at Gergovia, but was then trapped at **Alesia** in September 52 BCE. The Romans constructed an encircling rampart around the Gauls' position and managed to beat off a Gaulish relief force. With no hope left, **Vercingetorix surrendered** and was taken back to Rome, where he was strangled in 46 BCE after appearing in Caesar's triumphal parade.



CAESAR ENDED THE GALLIC REVOLT by the end of 51 BCE, but by this point the **Triumvirate** had ended: Pompey's supporters had turned against Caesar, and Crassus had been killed in battle in 53 BCE. The Senate ordered Caesar to disband his army or be declared an enemy of the state. Instead, he **crossed the Rubicon River** into Italy with his troops in 49 BCE. This was illegal, constituting a **declaration of war** against the Senate.

As **Caesar marched toward Rome**, town after town submitted to him. Fearing Caesar, **Pompey** left Rome and **fled to Greece**. Caesar turned first to Spain, where seven legions had declared for Pompey. In August

49 BCE, he forced the Pompeians there to surrender. In December, Caesar set off for Greece in pursuit of Pompey. A military engagement at **Dyrachium** in July went against Caesar, but he fought back before Pompey's support could grow, and won a resounding victory at **Pharsalus**. Pompey took refuge in Egypt, where he was murdered on the orders of **Ptolemy XIII**, who hoped (in vain) to ingratiate himself with Caesar.

After a short time in Egypt, **Caesar returned to Rome**, where he raised money by confiscating property from the supporters of Pompey. In late 47 BCE, Caesar set sail for Africa, where he defeated a new Pompeian army at **Thapsus** (in modern Tunisia). Pompey's sons Gnaeus and Sextus escaped to Spain to continue the resistance from there, and Caesar annexed the kingdom of King Juba of Mauretania, who had supported them. Caesar then proceeded to Spain, where in

KEY
 → Caesar's movements
 • Siege
 X Caesar's victories

Roman Civil Wars

Caesar won Italy easily, but he had to fight hard to overcome Pompey in his Greek stronghold, and then Pompey's sons and remaining supporters in Africa and Spain.

March 45 BCE he defeated Gnaeus Pompey at **Munda**, effectively ending the civil war.

Caesar was now all-powerful. He was made **dictator in 48 BCE**, and in 44 BCE he was given the office for life. Concerns over Caesar's power—in particular, fears that he planned to make himself king—led a group of about 60 conspirators to form around senators **Cassius** and **Marcus Brutus**. They **murdered Caesar** on the **Ides of March** (March 14)

just before a session of the Senate. If they had hoped to seize power, the conspirators were disappointed: **Mark Antony**, one of Caesar's leading supporters, came to the fore in Rome, while Caesar's great-nephew and adoptive son **Octavian** received widespread support in a bid to take up the mantle of his father.

In India, **Kalinga** (modern Orissa), which had been a client kingdom of the Mauryas (see 200–171 BCE), rose to prominence under **Kharavela** in the mid-1st century BCE. Kharavela expanded Kalinga far to the north and east, conquering the Sunga capital of Pataliputra in Magadha. A strong patron of the Indian religion of Jainism, Kharavela established **trading contacts** as far afield as Southeast Asia.

Murder of Caesar

Conspirators struck Caesar down with daggers. As he fell, Caesar saw **Marcus Brutus**, a former protégé, and cried out “you too, child?”



“THE DIE IS CAST.”

Julius Caesar to his troops on crossing the Rubicon in 49 BCE; from Plutarch's *Parallel Lives*

53 BCE Expedition of Crassus to Parthia ends in disaster, as his army is wiped out at Carrhae in Mesopotamia

52 BCE Vercingetorix leads new Gallic revolt, but is defeated

c. 50 BCE Teotihuacán in Mexico is the largest city in the Americas, with a population of 50,000

50 BCE Construction of a new forum in Rome

c. 50 BCE Kharavela of Kalinga carves out an empire in India

49 BCE Caesar crosses the Rubicon into Italy

48 BCE Pompey flees to Egypt and is killed there

48 BCE Herod becomes ruler of Galilee, ending the power of the Hasmoneans

47 BCE Caesar defeats Pharnaces of Pontus (son of Mithridates) at Zela

46 BCE Roman colony of Carthage founded; remaining supporters of Pompey defeated at Thapsus

46 BCE Juba of Numidia commits suicide after defeat at Thapsus; his kingdom is annexed by Rome

46 BCE Julian reform of the calendar: the “Year of Confusion” has 445 days

46 BCE Caesar appointed dictator

45 BCE Caesar defeats Pompey's sons at Battle of Munda

44 BCE Murder of Caesar

44 BCE Cleopatra becomes ruler of Egypt